2.1 Slavery Expands

A person journeying from New England to the Southern Colonies would be amazed by its large plantations—quite a contrast to New England's small farms. And the warm climate would probably make the traveler shed his or her jacket. What a difference geography makes!

MAIN IDEA The Southern Colonies developed a system of plantation agriculture that relied on increasing numbers of enslaved Africans.

PLANTATION CROPS

The geography of New England was very different from that of the Southern Colonies. The fertile land and milder climate of the Southern Colonies—Maryland, Virginia, the Carolinas, and Georgia—made it possible to grow **cash crops**, crops grown for sale rather than for use by the farmers themselves. The main cash crops were tobacco, rice, and **indigo**, a plant whose leaves provide a source of blue dye for cloth. Tobacco thrived in the hot and humid growing season of Virginia and coastal Maryland. Rice was well suited to the swampy lowlands and tidal areas of coastal rivers in the Carolinas. However, the colonists had no experience in rice cultivation. They depended on enslaved Africans, who had been taken from rice-growing regions in West Africa, to farm the rice and ensure successful yields.

Plantations sprang up along the rivers so planters could use the water for their rice fields. Ships sailed up tributaries from the Chesapeake Bay and docked at the plantations. Because of the ease of transporting goods directly from their farms, southern colonists had little need for port cities.

One exception was the busy seaport of **Charles Town** (now called Charleston). As Carolina planters developed cash crops, Charles Town grew as a port. Many plantation owners lived there part of the year to escape the isolation of their plantations. Although Charles Town became the fourth-largest colonial city, after Boston, Philadelphia, and New York, it never grew larger because English and New England shippers controlled its trade. Without a strong merchant community, the city failed to attract large numbers of new workers.

NEW SLAVE TRADING

Planters in the Southern Colonies originally hired white indentured servants to work for several years in exchange for a plot of land. But in 1698, England gave all English merchants permission to participate in slave trading. As a result, planters who lived in the **Chesapeake**, the settled land around the Chesapeake Bay, turned to enslaved Africans to farm their land. In 1660, only 900 Africans resided in the Chesapeake, some of whom had arrived as servants and lived free. By 1720, one-fifth of the population of that area were Africans. By 1770, that number ranged from one-third to one-half. African populations in Virginia and the Carolinas also increased dramatically during this period. By 1750, African Americans accounted for over 40 percent of Virginia's total population and more than half of South Carolina's. More than 90 percent of the total African-American population was enslaved.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why were tobacco and rice good cash crops for Virginia, Maryland, and the Carolinas?
2. **ANALYZE VISUALS** After which step in the rice process are the grains of rice collected?
3. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What factors led to the expansion of slave labor in the Southern Colonies?

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Rice Production

Rice production required many steps and many people to grow enough grain to make a profit. Below are some of the steps of this labor-intensive process.

1 Flooding

Farmworkers built flood gates and dug ditches. They planted, then opened the floodgates to fill the rice fields with water. After the seeds sprouted, the fields were drained so the women could weed. Then the fields were reflooded.



2 Harvesting

Workers harvested, or reaped, the ripened rice plants with a cutting tool called a scythe (SIGHTH).



3 Threshing

On colonial plantations, threshing meant beating the plants with a stick called a flail until the grains fell from the plants.



4 Winnowing

Winnowing was the process of tossing the rice grains in a basket to separate them from their tissue-like outer coating, or chaff.



5 Pounding

The winnowed rice was poured into a hollowed-out log and pounded with a staff called a mortar. This removed the tough outer husk from the grain.



In 1915, when these photographs were taken, slavery had been abolished, but workers still used tools similar to ones that had been used more than 200 years ago.

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